

Some Philosophic and Conceptual Ideas Important to Debate

Moral Imperative (or Moral Obligation)

It is something that must happen because it is the right thing; A moral imperative is an ethical responsibility. A line of conduct or behavior judged as the right one, by a majority of people within a community. An obligation or imperative is a duty or a command to act in a certain way. When the obligation is based on moral and ethical considerations, it is a moral duty. Moral obligations can arise from three sources.

1. **Law-Based Moral Obligations.** Good citizens have a moral as well as a legal obligation to abide by laws; it is part of the assumed social contract of a civilized society. If a law is unjust, however, (such as those that mandated ethnic and religious persecution during the Nazi regime and those that discriminated against a person on the basis of race in South Africa and elsewhere) there may be a moral obligation to disobey it under the specific and demanding doctrine of civil disobedience.
2. **Agreement-Based Moral Obligations.** The second source of moral obligation is agreement. Even if an agreement doesn't reach the level of an enforceable contract, there is a moral obligation to do the things we agree to do, especially if others are counting on us to do so. For instance, you agree to pay monthly payments toward your mortgage.
3. **Moral Principle as the Basis of Moral Obligation.** The third source of moral obligation is moral principle, a standard of conduct that exists irrespective of laws or agreements. The great German ethicist, Immanuel Kant is largely responsible for this idea – that we must do this because, within us, we know it is the right thing to do. (Josephson Institute, 3 Sources of Moral Obligation, 2/14/11)

In debate, you may debate you may argue that a plan, an idea, a law must be put in place because we have a moral imperative to do so. Moral imperative could also be a judging criteria.

Social Contract

The social contract is one of the foundations of the American political system. This is the belief that the state only exists to serve the will of the people, and they are the source of all political power enjoyed by the state. They can choose to give or withhold this power. English philosopher Thomas Hobbes is primarily responsible for the theory of a social contract. Hobbes' theory was that the people mutually agree to create a state (government), only giving it enough power to provide protection of their well-being. Jean Jacques Rousseau and John Locke each took the social contract theory one step further. Rousseau explained that the government is based on the idea of popular sovereignty. Thus the will of the people as a whole gives power and direction to the state. John Locke stressed the role of the individual. He also believed that revolution was not just a right but an obligation if the state abused their given power. Obviously these ideas had a huge impact on the Founding Fathers, especially Thomas Jefferson and James Madison. (Kelly, Martin, American history expert, Social Contract. <http://americanhistory.about.com/bio/Martin-Kelly-7762.htm>)

In debate, you might be arguing that we need to pass a law, follow a course of action etc. because it is really part of our social contract to our citizens.

Human Rights

Human rights are **rights** inherent to all **human** beings, whatever our nationality, place of residence, sex, national or ethnic origin, color, religion, language, or any other status. We are all equally entitled to our **human rights** without discrimination. Human rights are protected and upheld by international and national laws and treaties. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) was adopted by the United Nations General Assembly on December 10th, 1948. The Universal Declaration was the first time that countries agreed on a comprehensive statement of inalienable human rights. It is a vision for human dignity, committing governments to uphold the fundamental rights of each person. Here are some of the most important the rights listed in each of the articles of the Declaration of Human Rights:

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| 1 Right to Equality | 8 Right to Remember by Competent Tribunal |
| 2 Freedom from Discrimination | 9 Freedom from Arbitrary Arrest and Exile |
| 3 Right to Life, Liberty, Personal Security | 10 Right to Fair Public Hearing |
| 4 Freedom from Slavery | 11 Right to Innocence until Proven Guilty |
| 5 Freedom from Torture & Degrading Treatment | 12 Freedom from Interference with Privacy, Family, Home & Correspondence |
| 6 Right to Recognition as a Person before the Law | 13 Right to Free Movement in and out of the Country |
| 7 Right to Equality before the Law | |

- 14 Right to Asylum in other Countries from Persecution
- 15 Right to a Nationality & the Freedom to Change It
- 16 Right to Marriage and Family
- 17 Right to Own Property
- 18 Freedom of Belief and Religion
- 19 Freedom of Opinion and Information
- 20 Right of Peaceful Assembly and Association

- 21 Right to Participate in Government and in Free Elections
- 22 Right to Social Security
- 23 Right to Desirable Work; to Join Trade Unions
- 24 Right to Rest and Leisure
- 25 Right to Adequate Living Standard
- 26 Right to Education

In debate, you might be arguing that a law must be passed, a policy must be followed, or a value must be a priority because it involves a basic human right.

Values

1. Values are important and lasting beliefs or ideals shared by the members of a culture about what is good or bad and desirable or undesirable. Values have major influence on a person's behavior and attitude and serve as broad guidelines in all situations. Some common business values are fairness, innovation and community involvement. 2. The monetary worth of something in areas such as accounting, economics, marketing or mathematics.

In debate, you may be arguing that something is a value that is threatened, that a value must be protected by law, that one value is more important to people than another.

Engagement

Civic engagement or **civic participation** has been defined as "Individual and collective actions designed to identify and address issues of public concern. Civic engagement in its most basic sense is about decision making. The principle of civic engagement resides ultimately in the citizens. Civic engagement is about the right of the people to define the public good, determine the policies by which they will seek the good, and reform/replace institutions that do not serve that good. Civic engagement can also be summarized as a means of working together to make a difference in the life of our communities and developing the skills, knowledge, values, and motivation in order to make that difference. It means promoting a quality of life in a community, through both **political** and **non-political** processes. (Wikipedia, accessed 10/4/14)

Civic engagement can take many forms—from individual volunteerism to organizational involvement to electoral participation. It can include efforts to directly address an issue, work with others in a community to solve a problem or interact with the institutions or governments. Nowadays, the most widely accepted canon for good citizenship is Michael Schudson's '**monitorial citizen**' – citizens scan the environment and intervene or get active only when a threat is sensed (Schudson, 1998) Other definitions emphasize the political aspect of "civic", with "activities that are specifically political (i.e., that involve government action)"(Ekman, Joakim et al. "Political Participation and Civic Engagement: Towards a New Typology. HUMAN AFFAIRS 22, 283–300, 2012 DOI: 10.2478/s13374-012-0024-1) Some say that political engagement refers to attempts to influence *others* and the decisions that they make concerning societal issues.)"(Ekman, Joakim et al. "Political Participation and Civic Engagement: Towards a New Typology. HUMAN AFFAIRS 22, 283–300, 2012 DOI: 10.2478/s13374-012-0024-1)

Teorell et al. (2007) suggest a more extensive definition of engagement. *Electoral participation* is the first of these. *Consumer participation* covers donating money to charity, boycotting and political consumption, as well as signing petitions. In a manner of speaking, it taps the role of citizens as critical consumers. The third dimension is *party activity*: to be a member of, active within, do voluntary work for or donating money to a political party. *Protest activity* is the fourth dimension, which covers acts like taking part in demonstrations, strikes and other protest activities. Contacting organizations, politicians or civil servants constitute the fifth dimension, *contact activity*. (Ekman, Joakim et al. "Political Participation and Civic Engagement: Towards a New Typology. HUMAN AFFAIRS 22, 283–300, 2012 DOI: 10.2478/s13374-012-0024-1)

In debate, the way one defines "engagement" could become important. Is it political or non-political participation, is it to help with situation or is it to influence others, is it done through elections, protests, or a monetary contribution? And who should be doing it – the individual, non-profit groups, special interest groups, or the government? It would become important to understand how this term is defined in order to set up the limits of the debate. And the Negative might choose to disagree with the definition of engagement, thus changing the nature of the debate.